

Radiotherapy explained

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to treat cancer. Radiotherapy is used to cure some types of cancer or to relieve symptoms.

Radiotherapy

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays (radiation) to treat cancer.

Side effects of radiotherapy

Radiotherapy can cause side effects. Your radiography team will give you advice or medicines to help manage them.

Your radiotherapy team

A team of specialists are involved in planning and giving your radiotherapy.

Radiotherapy masks

During most types of radiotherapy to the brain, head or neck, you wear a mask to help you lie still.

Pelvic radiotherapy

Radiotherapy treats cancer by using high-energy rays to destroy the cancer cells. Using radiotherapy to treat cancer in the pelvis is called pelvic radiotherapy.

External beam radiotherapy

External beam radiotherapy is given from a radiotherapy machine outside the body.

Internal radiotherapy

Internal radiotherapy uses a radioactive material that is put inside the body to treat cancer.

Proton beam therapy

Proton beam therapy is a type of external beam radiotherapy. It is only suitable for a small number of people.

Stereotactic ablative radiotherapy (SABR)

Stereotactic ablative radiotherapy (SABR) is a way of giving radiotherapy to precisely target certain cancers.

Selective internal radiation therapy (SIRT)

Selective internal radiation therapy (SIRT) uses radioactive beads to treat cancer in the liver.

Get help with money and work

If you're worried about how cancer might affect things like money and work, Macmillan is here to help.

[Find out more](#)

How we can help



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.



Cancer information in other formats and languages

We have information about radiotherapy in 16 different languages and other formats, including audiobooks and easy read booklets. You can also request information in any language or

format.